



WOMEN MAOISTS PROTEST AGAINST THE LEFT FRONT GOVERNMENT

Equally EXTREME

Women are swelling the ranks of Maoists across their rural hinterland, providing logistical support, shelter and even taking up arms against the security forces

| By Abhijit Dasgupta |

On a wintry November day in 2008 after a landmine explosion missed West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya's convoy by minutes, the police raided several villages in the Maoist-infested Lalgarh district of West Bengal. Among those who were rounded up was 55-year-old Chintamani Murmu of Chotopelia village, a mother of three who ended up losing an eye. The women of Lalgarh have since then seemingly vowed to seek an eye for eye. In less than the two years that it has taken for Lalgarh to turn into West Bengal's latest inferno, one feature stands out

prominently: women have been cooking this poison broth.

The trainjacking of the Delhi-bound Rajdhani Express on October 27 had one distinguishing factor. The offenders were all People's Committee against Police Atrocities (PCPA) supporters brandishing, at the most, bows and arrows and stones to hurl. Fifty per cent of the PCPA's members are women.

It turned out that the PCPA had a membership ratio of 50:50 between the genders, something quite un-

heard of. Maoist leader Bimal, in an interview shortly after the formation of the group, had said, "Many oppressed women have joined us. But in Bengal, their numbers are fewer than in other states. Everywhere else, the ratio is almost 60:40 in favour of women." Since then, however, the numbers of women have swelled among the villagers ranks who root for the Maoists and give them shelter. After the joint forces started operations in Lalgarh and the Maoists were banned, women came out in the

“Many oppressed women have joined us. The ratio is 60:40 in favour of women in all states other than West Bengal.”

BIMAL, Maoist leader